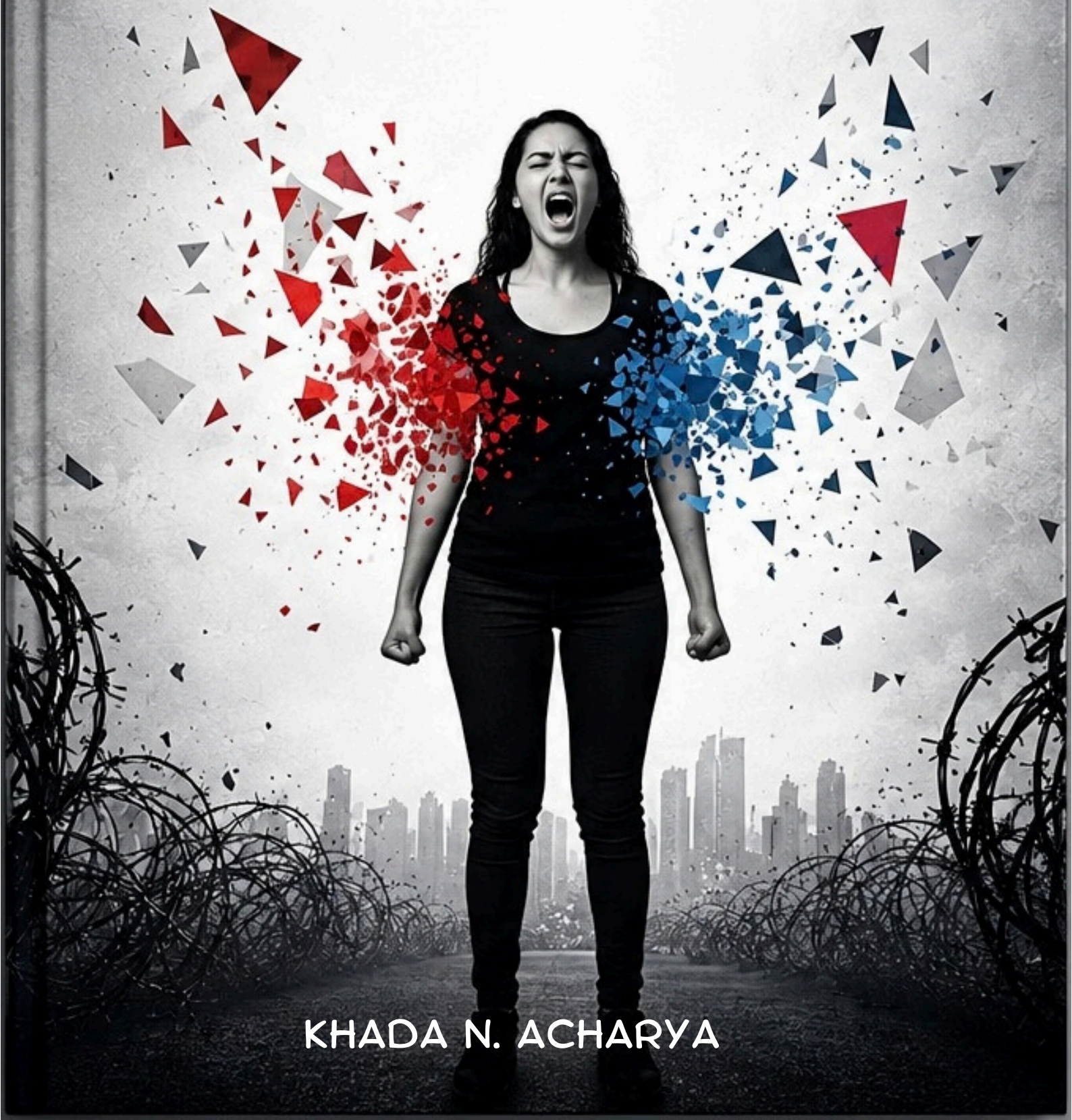


SILENCE IN THE WORLD: **UNDEFINED**

CONFRONTING SYSTEMIC INJUSTICE.



KHADA N. ACHARYA

Silence In The World: Undefined

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Disclaimer

This is a work of real stories with a twist. Names and characters are made up to make sure nobody was hurt. Places and events are real but shown creatively.

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Dedication

To ***Michael Brown*** , and to every innocent person whose name became a hashtag instead of a headline.

To every ***undocumented immigrant*** who lives with the sound of a knock on the door.

To ***Muhammad Ali*** , and to the Muslim men who keep choosing to change the world through peace — and will.

To ***Madeleine Kunin*** , and to every refugee who has had to out-grow their fear just to build a life.

Contents

<i>Introduction</i>	04
A Silent Cry	
<i>Chapter One</i>	05-06
Wow, Unique World	
<i>Chapter Two</i>	07-09
O Cruel Heart	
<i>Chapter Three</i>	10-11
I Am a Muslim Man	
<i>Chapter Four</i>	12-15
The Refuge	
<i>Conclusion</i>	16
Breaking the Silence	
About the Author	

*INTRODUCTION**A Silent Cry*

Silence in the World: Undefined is a testament to the injustice that continues to shape lives in this country and beyond. It moves through the heart of racial inequality in the United States, and it lingers on the experiences of people whose voices have been talked over, doubted, or erased outright.

This is not a formal study. It is a collection of stories, images, and observations — some drawn from headlines, some drawn from the life of a refugee who arrived in this country carrying more questions than answers. What connects every chapter is silence: the silence forced onto people, and the silence people learn to choose for themselves because speaking has always felt too dangerous.

These chapters are not offered as arguments to be won. They are offered as mirrors. Some readers will see themselves in these pages. Others will see people they have never before had a reason to think about closely. Both readings matter equally.

Your part in this is not passive. Share this book. Argue with it. Pass it to someone who needs to sit with a story that isn't their own for a while. That, too, is how silence breaks — not all at once, but one conversation at a time.

If this book does only one thing, may it be this: that it makes the silence a little harder to keep.

*CHAPTER ONE**Wow, Unique World*

There is a house called Ferguson, in a country I will call the Motherland.

In that house lives an old animal everyone calls Master Justice. Master Justice listens to everyone — except the family he was born to protect. He says he has no family, only friends, and those friends stand close around him at all times. But Master Justice never truly listens to the poor. Not the poor who are Black. Not the poor who are white.

Far from Ferguson, I live in a place I call Vital Land. Here, the Master Justices help each other, and the animals look out for one another. There is a small, plain house here called Helpful. I work there. I love the animals I care for. I love what tomorrow looks like from inside that house.

Then, one bitter Friday, Master Justice in Ferguson goes blind.

No one steps in to care for his animals. His friends promise, “We will help,” and instead they fling open every cage. “Free!” they shout, and the animals scatter in every direction at once. Peace, which had never been more than skin-deep to begin with, dies completely. What follows isn’t liberation. It is a fight nobody agreed to have.

In one part of Ferguson live the well-fed white animals. In another part live the well-fed Black animals. Everywhere else — in the cracks between those two neighborhoods — live the animals who are hungry, whatever color their fur happens to be. The well-fed animals, Black and white alike, start to believe the hungry Black animals are dangerous by nature. But the hungry white animals refuse to believe it. They stand with the hungry Black animals, because hunger, it turns out, teaches its own kind of solidarity that comfort never has to learn.

Back home in Vital Land, we still fight for what is right, and right stays right, and wrong stays wrong. It isn’t Ferguson. Not yet.

Then the news breaks.

A well-fed white cat corners a hungry Black mouse. No reason is ever given. The cat kills the mouse anyway. Protests spread through every corner of the Motherland. Animals scream into the street, “This s wrong!”

— and the cat walks free, because Master Justice’s friends had already decided what happened before they ever told him.

He believes them. He is blind, after all, and belief has always been easier to hold onto than sight.

Today, the killing continues in Ferguson — slower now, spread thinner across more places, so that it draws less attention with each repetition. The hungry Black animals still fight for something worth naming. Master Justice stays blind, on purpose now more than by accident.

I keep asking myself: what about Vital Land? Will this unity survive? Will freedom curdle into a war here too, the way it did in Ferguson?

Ask yourself the same questions:

- Am I free, or am I only unbothered?
- What happens to my home if it becomes Ferguson?
- Do I want to live in the Motherland, or in a house called Helpful?

Here is what I have learned: freedom, left unexamined, is a story people tell themselves. The Motherland was built on that story. It still runs on it. It will keep running on it for as long as Master Justice keeps choosing belief over sight, and for as long as telling the truth is treated as the crime, instead of the silence that let the truth happen in the first place.

Our children may grow up not knowing what the word “freedom” was supposed to mean — only what it has come to mean instead — because Master Justice was too weak, or too comfortable, to open his eyes.

However long the protests last:

- Justice does not arrive on its own.
- Hungry Black animals still die for reasons no one will name out loud.
- Well-fed white animals still walk free.
- And freedom, for them, still means the freedom to do it again.

CHAPTER TWO

O Cruel Heart

Mrs. Hope's class is watching a short film called *Easy Death*. Before the story starts, two lines flash across the screen:

*Don't be the Knife that breaks the Wood.
Be the Glue that mends it.*

Then the music starts — a slow, uneasy hum — and an unnamed narrator sits by a pond, holding a book titled *Real or Reality?*

In a place called the Friendship World, three neighbors live side by side. Glue, to the north, quiet and steady. Knife, in the middle, loud and certain of its own strength. Wood, to the south, patient, and used to being cut.

For a long time, the three help each other. Glue mends what breaks. Wood gives what it can. Knife protects — or says it does. Friendship is the whole world they know.

Then a Creature arrives. He looks almost like a bomb, but not quite — something built to go off eventually, dressed up as something else in the meantime.

The Creature smiles, but the smile doesn't reach anywhere real. Knife narrows its eyes. "Why are you here?"

"To help you," the Creature says.

"What? What?"

"You are the greatest thing in this world," the Creature says, and smiles again. "Knife — why share this world with anyone? Break Wood. Chop Glue. Rule alone."

"WHAT? WHAT?"

"You were born sharp," the Creature says. "Stay sharp. Break Wood. Kill Glue."

“Yes,” Knife says slowly. “But I never tried.”

“Do it now,” the Creature says. “This chance will not return.”

Knife imagines the shape of that kind of power and walks toward Wood’s house. There, Knife finds Glue and Wood talking together — quietly, the way old neighbors do. Knife had forbidden this once, a long time ago, in a voice nobody quite remembers agreeing to obey.

“WHAT IS THIS?” Knife screams.

Glue and Wood go silent. Knife breaks Wood into two pieces.

The Creature reappears. “Now chop Glue.”

Knife hesitates — Glue had mended Knife once, back when Knife still needed mending.

The Creature grabs Glue anyway. “Chop it, or I take it myself.”

Glue doesn’t fight. Glue only whispers, “Do it. This is what friendship costs now.”

Knife chops. Glue’s pieces fall — and land, unexpectedly, on Wood’s broken half. Wood becomes whole again. The screen goes black. The film ends.

The bell rings. Class should end, but nobody moves. Lunch is waiting, but the students stay in their seats.

“Is Glue gone?” someone asks.

Mrs. Hope says, “Glue saved friendships. Glue brought whatever joy this world had. Now? Gone.”

“Why? Where did Glue go?”

Nobody answers. Lunch ends. The students leave without one, because there isn’t an answer that fits in the time left before the next bell.

Here is the truth Mrs. Hope never had to say out loud, because by then, everyone in that room already knew it:

- Glue is Canada.
- Knife is the United States.
- Wood is Mexico.
- The Creature is Donald Trump.

- The Friendship World is North America.

Ask yourself:

- Who did the most damage here — the Creature who whispered, or the Knife who listened?
- Which one are you, when someone hands you a reason to stop sharing what you have?
- If you were Glue, and you knew exactly what it would cost you — would you still choose to mend?

*CHAPTER THREE**I Am a Muslim Man*

There are 1.6 billion Muslims in the world. 1.6 billion people who believe in Allah, the way I do.

Ask me who I believe in, and my answer changes depending on one thing only: whether you already know I am a Muslim man.

The question “who am I?” follows me everywhere. Some people call me a terrorist before I’ve said a word. Some see genocide in my beard. Some just see a hater, because that is the only shape they’ve ever been given to put me in. All of it happens before anyone has asked me a single real question. All of it, because I am a Muslim man.

Here is the strange part: none of them know me. None of them know what is actually in my heart. They know a headline, and they have decided the headline is enough.

Talking to me isn’t dangerous. It is the opposite — when you ask me something, I give you a true answer, even when the true answer is inconvenient.

You ask if I know Yahweh. I tell you I am, in that sense, a Jew.

You ask if I know Jesus. I tell you I am a Christian.

You ask if I know Guru Gobind Singh. I tell you I am a Sikh.

You ask about Buddha, about Vishnu. I tell you I am Buddhist. Hindu.

Not because I am confused about who I am. Because I have read your books, prayed in your buildings, and found the same instruction sitting at the bottom of every one of them: don’t kill, love the young, respect the old. I know your religion the way you should know it — not as a brand, not as a business, but as a set of promises people made to each other a long time ago and are still trying to keep.

Then you ask if I know Allah, and I finally say the one true thing: “I am a Muslim man.” And that is when you flinch — as if the ground under the conversation just changed. As if all those other answers were fine, but this is the one that’s dangerous.

But I didn’t change. You did.

I go to your church, your temple, your stupa. I read your book, even though it isn't the Quran. I pray there — not to erase what I believe, but because I believe prayer is the same conversation, held in different languages, aimed at the same listener. I see Allah everywhere: in your god, in your neighbor's god, in the god you stopped believing in. God is not divided up by address. God is one thing wearing a thousand names.

That unsettles people more than almost anything else I say. "Your god is mine," I tell them. "Mine is yours." Different paths, same destination — that is all religion has ever really been.

I know what you are afraid of. Radicals exist. Groups like ISIS kill in the name of a religion, and they kill Muslims more than anyone else while they do it. They are not believers. They are not people like me. Painting every Muslim man with that brush is like painting every American with the worst thing an American has ever done.

So let me say this plainly, once, instead of a hundred times:

I am not a terrorist. I am a Muslim man. I hate what terrorism does, exactly the way you do.

I intend to help change this world, and I intend to do it without violence — because I know you, and I have taken the time to know your religions too, even on the days you haven't returned the favor.

You don't know me. You call me a terrorist anyway. Thank you for that, honestly — it tells me exactly how much work is left to do. I plan to do it with love, with faith, and with the plain fact of showing up, again and again, until the shape you've built in your head stops matching the man standing in front of you.

I don't hate you, even on the days you've made it easy to. Allah teaches love over hate — not as a slogan, but as the harder, slower, more demanding choice. I mean to change this world with holy words. Not holy war.

*CHAPTER FOUR**The Refuge*

In this world there are winners and there are losers. Here is the strange part: I was born a winner, and I didn't understand what I had won until years later.

I hold a title most people never have to hold — a title where, on paper, everybody wins and nobody loses. People have called that idea foolish. Called the whole way I talk about it naive. Maybe it is. But I was born holding it anyway, so I've had a long time to make peace with the label.

I won this title because of Bhutan.

Bhutan calls itself “the world's happiest country,” and by most measures of scenery, it earns that name. But the beauty I know was built by the blood and sweat of my grandparents and parents — not the postcard version of the country, but the version that decided, in the late 1980s and early 1990s, that people like us — ethnic Nepali, Lhotshampa, whatever word you want to use — no longer belonged inside its borders. Over a hundred thousand people were pushed out. My family was among them.

I grew up knowing something most kids never have to learn on purpose: happiness is not the same thing as comfort. Struggle, lived through and shared, is its own kind of happiness. I know how strange that sounds. I mean it anyway.

We struggled in specific ways. Never quite enough food. Education that existed, technically, but was broken in all the ways that matter. No real hope of the camp ever becoming permanent, and no real hope of leaving it either — which is its own kind of prison. We were prisoners, in the end, of a situation none of us had chosen and none of us could vote our way out of.

You can argue that struggle and happiness cancel each other out. I'll disagree every time. My late father used to say, “A struggling life beats a king's life,” and I've watched that sentence prove itself out in small ways ever since. Not enough food? You share it. One pencil for three kids? You break it into three parts and share that too. No real hope? You tell your friends, ‘one day, better’ — and you mean it enough that it starts to function like a plan.

Happiness, in the camp, was never something that arrived. It was something you built, on purpose, out of whatever you had left. You call that “helping people get by.” I call it happiness, plainly, because that

is what it was.

I won this title at birth. The happiest country in the world made my family leave it, and in that leaving, I somehow ended up on the winning side of an equation nobody else could see. Struggle equals happiness — not because struggle feels good, but because of what struggle forces you to build with the people standing next to you.

Was I happy landing in the U.S.A.? No. Not then. Not fully now, either, because part of me is still back in Bhutan, in the version of the country that pushed us out.

I was a winner. I am a winner. I'll go on being one — half-brain or not, in this so-called "land of freedom" where, at first, nobody had any idea what title I was carrying.

At school, everyone was human to everyone else — except, somehow, me. I was the immigrant. I never understood why being an immigrant made me less human in anyone's eyes, when the only thing I'd actually done was survive a title I was born holding.

Here is a small, telling detail: my English teacher couldn't believe I was an immigrant, because my English sounded like the English everyone around me spoke. As if immigrants arrive without language. As if fluency is supposed to be the exception, not the rule. That teacher, at least, gave me refuge in the smallest sense of the word — she saw me instead of the story she'd been told to expect.

When people learn I'm from Nepal, they ask about Kathmandu. Pokhara. Whether I've seen Everest. I understand the impulse — but it stings a little, every time, that nobody asks about the camp instead. About what it took to survive it. Most of the students around me don't know to ask, because the camp isn't something you learn about unless you were born inside one.

When I tell people I'm from the camp instead, something worse happens. Nepali students and American students both, in their own ways, decide I must be dangerous — because of a beard, because of the language I speak at home. "You're Nepali," they say, as if that settles something. I speak Nepali. I am Nepali by blood. None of that makes the rest of what they're implying true. Nobody believes the fuller story, so eventually I stopped offering it in full.

I asked some of them once, "Who are you, really?" They said, "Nepali friends." Some just said, "Nepali." I noticed something had shifted in them along the way — they had become the very label I was being handed as a threat. I was still the one called a terrorist for the crime of not cutting my hair, not shaving my beard.

For a while, I wondered if I should just change to match them. I used to introduce myself as Nepali, plainly, and get asked about Kathmandu and Everest in return — pleasant questions, but ones that skipped straight past the camp, past the place I was actually born and actually struggled. There was no

room in those questions for pride in that place.

So I changed my answer. Now I say, “I am Bhutanese. My family is from Bhutan” — not because it’s more accurate, but because it opens a door to the part of the story people usually skip. It invites the question about the land I struggled in, instead of the land I merely descend from.

Even then, the question I get most is some version of, “So — are you happy in the U.S.A. now?” As if happiness and freedom are the same transaction. As if arriving somewhere freer automatically means arriving somewhere happier. Nobody asks what happiness actually meant back where I came from, or why struggle became the key to it in the first place.

So I explain it plainly when I can: I was born in a refugee camp, because Bhutan expelled my family. People don’t always believe that part. They think I’m hiding some simpler, sunnier answer — as if the real path to happiness has to be a secret, instead of something built in full view, out of hardship, in front of everyone.

I don’t hide it. I found happiness in the struggle itself. Struggle equals happiness — not a slogan, a fact I lived through.

There is no such thing as a loser in the game I am describing. It is a game most people don’t believe I actually won, because it reminds them too much of the camp they’ve never had to see. Nobody loses in it. I win it my way. Other people win theirs.

Why am I a winner, with no loser standing across from me? Not because I am different from anyone born here. We are all human. We all get to win, in our own currency, and we should all be cheering each other on while we do it.

There is an old saying: “Where there’s a will, there’s a way.” My version of it is simpler: where there’s a winner, there’s no need for a loser. I was handed this title at birth, and I have come to understand it is not an enemy — it is a winner’s title, one that costs nothing in violence and takes nothing away from anyone else to hold.

The title is this: ***The Refuge***.

Call it strange if you want. I carry it anyway. Winning, it turns out, was never really about the podium — it was about a world where everybody gets to stand on one at the same time, and nobody has to be pushed off to make room.

The man who carries “The Refuge” as a title has an obligation that comes with it: not to turn around and refuse the next person who needs one. Refugees, worldwide, keep getting called foolish, or dangerous, or both — the same way I was. I won’t do that to them. I can’t. Refusing them would mean refusing the

truth of where I came from.

You will extend refuge to me, sometimes, and still refuse to extend it to the next person standing where I once stood. I don't understand that math. Those people might be exactly the talent this world is short on. They are winners too, by the only definition of the word that has ever made sense to me.

A winner where nobody loses — that is the whole of the title I carry. Remember this, if nothing else: you may not extend refuge to them. I will keep fighting for the ones who need it. With words. Not with war.

*CONCLUSION**Breaking the Silence*

From Ferguson's streets to a border redrawn by cruelty, from a prayer said in someone else's language to a name typed onto a refugee file — silence is the oxygen that injustice breathes. Take it away, and injustice suffocates a little faster.

This book was never meant to be a study. It is a scream aimed at that particular void — the one that opens up whenever someone decides silence is safer than the truth.

Here is what I am asking of you, plainly, the way I have tried to write everything else in this book:

- **Speak.** Name injustice out loud when you see it, especially when naming it costs you something.
- **Listen.** Put the voices that are usually pushed to the margins back at the center of the room.
- **Resist.** Refuse to let your own silence become one more brick in the wall.

I don't know if this book changes anything on its own. Books rarely do, by themselves. But silence has never once fixed anything either — and I would rather be wrong out loud than quiet and safe.

About the Author



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Khada's work is forged in the fires of displacement and resilience. He holds an Associate of Arts in Liberal Studies and writes to dismantle the silence that suffocates the oppressed.

Book Design: Khada N. Acharya

SILENCE IN THE WORLD: UNDEFINED

*“In this world, everyone will try to silence you.
But do not hesitate to resist.”*

Silence in the World: Undefined is a powerful exploration of the invisible battles people face in a society built on inequality, fear and control.

Through raw emotion and unflinching truth, this book uncovers the many forms of systemic injustice — from silenced voices and broken dreams to the courage it takes to speak, resist and reclaim one's identity.

*A powerful exploration of silence, injustice,
identity and the courage to resist.*

